Plan a circle: “The Gettysburg Address”

Abraham Lincoln (1863) · public-domain speech (nonfiction) · grades 6–12 · ~2–3 class sessions. Rights: Public domain.

Kit section 5 (group agreement & calendar) filled in for one text — a finished plan students see before writing their own. ***Tinted italic*** = sample answers.

Text, group, and target

Text / author / edition	***“The Gettysburg Address” — Abraham Lincoln (1863). Public-domain speech (nonfiction).***
Group / period / dates	***Ana’s group · Period __ · Meetings ___ & ___***
Grade / TEKS target (p. 3)	Grade 8 · §110.24 — 9(D): rhetorical devices; 8(D): argument/claim; 1(D): student-led discussion. (Nonfiction: replace the literary focus with your course’s informational/argumentative expectation.)
Learning intention	We are learning to explain how Lincoln’s structure and word choices advance his purpose.
Success criteria	I bring one open question, cite two details with locations, respond to a peer, and name how my thinking changed.

Reading map & calendar

Chunk	Read through	Meeting date · leader
1	***“Four score” — the founding and the present dedication of the cemetery.***	***Day 1 · Leader: Ana***
2	***The living’s “unfinished work” and the “new birth of freedom.”***	***Day 2 · Leader: Jon***

Members & first-meeting jobs (p. 7 roles)

Member	First job	Rotates to (next meeting)
Ana	***Questioner***	***Summarizer***
Jon	***Summarizer***	***Clarifier***
Mia	***Clarifier***	***Evidence tracker***
Cole	***Predictor***	***Questioner***

Text-specific discussion questions (open — more than one answer)

- **Predict:** A speech at a battlefield cemetery — what will Lincoln ask the living to do? What in the opening hints at it?
- **Question:** Why might Lincoln spend so little time on the dead and more on the living?
- **Clarify:** What is the “unfinished work” and the “great task remaining”?
- **Summarize:** State Lincoln’s main claim in one sentence, without opinion.
- **Interpret the theme:** How do repetition and contrast (past / present / future) advance his purpose? Use two details.

> **Optional Jigsaw lenses (p. 4):** ***Purpose*** (why Lincoln speaks) · ***Structure*** (past → present → future) · ***Language*** (repetition: “dedicate,” “we cannot”) · ***Rhetoric*** (appeals to shared ideals) · ***Context*** (the Civil War, 1863).

Sample 3–2–1 notes: Mia, structure lens

Name: Mia · Home group: Ana's group · Period __ · Meetings ___ & ___ · Section: "The Gettysburg Address," whole speech · Expert lens: Structure

> **What a finished prep looks like.** Kit section 6 / Organizer A completed for one reader, so students can compare their notes to a strong model.

Questions ***Why say the world will "little note" the speech?*** ***What is the "new birth of freedom"?***	**3 · Important ideas** ***1. Lincoln opens with the nation's founding in 1776.*** ***2. He turns to the present dedication of the cemetery.*** ***3. He ends by charging the living with the unfinished work.***
Vocabulary ***consecrate = to make sacred.*** ***proposition = a claim put forward.***	**2 · Supporting details** ***1. "Four score and seven years ago" (opening) roots the nation in its founding ideals.*** ***2. "government of the people, by the people, for the people" (ending) names the goal to preserve.***

1 · Summary in my own words

Lincoln honors the dead briefly, then calls the living to finish the work of preserving a government by the people.

Bring to the circle

My interpretation: ***The speech reframes a burial as a call to continue the nation's founding ideals.***
Synthesis (two lenses): ***The past-present-future structure serves the purpose: by moving from 1776 to "unfinished work," Lincoln turns mourning into commitment. Text points: the opening and the closing line.***
After discussion: ***My thinking became clearer once the group compared evidence.***

TEKS evidence: 6(C,D) supported inference; 7(A) theme through characters/events; 1(D) response to a peer. · Pair with the PlotPoint "The Gettysburg Address" room.